number were wounded. A chilling account of these foolhardy and ill-conceived operations, but with outstanding junior leadership and youthful bravado, is given in the book *Fangs of Ice – Story of Siachen* by Lieutenant Colonel Ishfaq Ali of the Pakistan Army.

Since then the Pakistan Army has been desperately trying to get a foothold on the Saltoro range, but we have managed to frustrate every design of theirs. Having taken a number of casualties each time, Pakistan finally gave up making any more serious attempts to attack our positions in the Siachen area. However, artillery duels continued with great intensity, till the ceasefire in 2003. Both sides suffered a number of casualties, more on account of the high altitude, avalanches, accidents and medical causes. Just to maintain the troops in those positions has been at a price. But the fact remains that Siachen is Indian territory and even if we withdraw from the positions on the Saltoro range, we would have to keep adequate number of soldiers fully acclimatized and ready to defend our territory in this region. These troops will perforce have to be kept in the base camp area, and we would have to bear that expense anyway. Therefore, the cost factor loses its relevance considerably. Further, the human cost in terms of casualties due to altitude and extreme cold conditions has also been brought down to fairly acceptable levels.

Apart from exercising our right to safeguard our territorial integrity, there are some important gains achieved by our deployment in Siachen. By holding the Saltoro range we are in a position to deny direct access to the Karakoram Pass to Pakistan, and also retain a capability to exert some influence on the Indian territory in the Shaksgam valley, which Pakistan has illegally ceded to China. However, in the agreement with Pakistan, the Chinese have taken abundant precaution of qualifying that the agreement would be subject to renegotiation with the side that has sovereignty over the area, once the issue of Kashmir is resolved.

Over the years, there have been a series of talks and meetings to find a way to resolve the Siachen issue. I participated in the seventh round of talks in 1998 in New Delhi as the ADGMO. During these talks, we made our position clear that we were prepared to